Fossil Forgotten in a Museum Drawer Reveals a New Dinosaur

From: ScienceDaily Most Popular Mined: 2026-10-15 5 min read

A dinosaur **fossil** that sat almost unnoticed in a museum for nearly 100 years has turned out to be a brand-new **species**. The **predator** lived about 120 million years ago in what is now Britain.

Scientists led by University College London (UCL) studied a piece of the back of a dinosaur skull found on the Isle of Wight, an island off England's southern coast. London's Natural History Museum got the **fossil** in 1924, but no one realized how important it was.

The researchers named the dinosaur Invictibellatrix amberina. The name means "unconquered female warrior." It belongs to a mysterious group of meat-eating dinosaurs called **megaraptorans**. They walked on two legs and were related to Tyrannosaurus rex. But instead of using giant jaws, **megaraptorans** had narrow skulls, strong arms and huge curved claws for catching food.

Lead author Dr. Cassius Morrison said the dinosaur was probably three to four meters long and about as tall as a person. It likely had feathers, and its claws may have been 10 to 20 centimeters long. It probably ate small dinosaurs, lizards and mammals. Morrison noted that a human would have been the right size **prey** for this hunter, while a T. rex would not have bothered. Of course, people and dinosaurs never lived at the same time.

The **fossil** also solves a puzzle. Scientists thought **megaraptorans** first appeared in Asia and then spread through Europe to southern lands such as Africa and South America. But no megaraptoran had ever been found in Europe until now.

"This new **species** is the first proof we have that **megaraptorans** were also present in Europe," said UCL student Charlie Scherer.

Morrison said many bones are found on the Isle of Wight. "Who knows what else is waiting to be discovered," he said.

Word Treasure

fossil -- A fossil is the preserved remains or trace of a plant or animal from long ago.

species -- A species is one particular kind of living thing, such as lions or house cats.

predator -- A predator is an animal that hunts and eats other animals.

megaraptorans -- Megaraptorans are a group of meat-eating dinosaurs known for strong arms and huge curved claws.

prey -- Prey is an animal that is hunted and eaten by another animal.

Background you need

Museums store huge collections of fossils, and some are not studied closely until many years after they are found.

Scientists can identify a new dinosaur from just part of a skeleton by comparing its shape with fossils of related animals.

Megaraptorans were meat-eating dinosaurs related to Tyrannosaurus rex, but they caught food with strong arms and large curved claws rather than giant jaws.

Because their fossils are rare, scientists have had trouble working out where megaraptorans first lived and how they spread to lands such as Africa and South America.

Break it down

LEAD: A fossil overlooked in a museum for nearly 100 years is a new dinosaur species.
KEY EVENT: Scientists identify Invictibellatrix amberina
+- WHO: Researchers led by University College London
+- WHERE: Skull piece found on the Isle of Wight; held by London's Natural History Museum since 1924
+- WHEN: Lived about 120 million years ago
DESCRIPTION: A megaraptoran three to four meters long, about as tall as a person, likely feathered, with long claws
EVIDENCE: First megaraptoran found in Europe, supporting the idea they spread from Asia through Europe to southern lands
OPEN QUESTION: What else is waiting to be discovered on the Isle of Wight?

Why it matters

The discovery fills a gap in the story of how a mysterious group of dinosaurs spread across the world, and shows that old museum collections can still hold surprises.

Test what you remember

1. How long did the fossil sit mostly unnoticed in a museum?

- (A) Nearly 100 years
- (B) About 10 years
- (C) Only one year
- (D) About 500 years

2. Where was the fossil found?

- (A) In South America
- (B) On the Isle of Wight
- (C) In Asia
- (D) In Antarctica

3. What does the name Invictibellatrix mean?

- (A) Feathered king
- (B) Unconquered female warrior
- (C) Island lizard
- (D) Tiny swift hunter

4. How did megaraptorans mainly catch their food?

- (A) With poison
- (B) With strong arms and huge curved claws
- (C) By flying
- (D) With giant jaws only

5. About how tall was the dinosaur, according to Dr. Cassius Morrison?

- (A) Taller than a T. rex
- (B) About as tall as a person
- (C) As tall as a house
- (D) As small as a cat

6. Why is this fossil important for understanding megaraptorans?

- (A) It proves dinosaurs lived with people
- (B) It is the largest dinosaur ever
- (C) It is the first megaraptoran found in Europe
- (D) It shows they lived in the ocean

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Dr. Cassius Morrison, lead author: He describes the dinosaur's size and diet and says it is a mystery the fossil was overlooked for so long.

2. Charlie Scherer, UCL student: He says the species is the first proof that megaraptorans were present in Europe.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):